expectations that it would usher in additional GDP growth of about 2 per cent and would also impart buoyancy to the indirect taxation system.

Unfortunately, these hopes have been belied.

For the nine months of financial year 2017–18, total GST revenues amounted to Rs 7.40 lakh crore at an average of Rs 82,294 crore. Though GST was expected to generate gross tax revenues of about Rs 1 lakh crore per month, in no month did revenues cross this mark.

In 2018–19, which was the first full year of the GST system, gross tax revenues generated by all the components of the GST system (CGST, SGST, IGST with its two components of domestic and imports and Compensation Cess with its components of domestic and imports) was Rs 11.77 lakh crore; an average of Rs 98,114 crore per month. In this year, gross GST collections crossed Rs 1 lakh three times in the months of April, January and March with March 2019 recording the highest revenue of Rs 1,06,577 crore.

The year 2019–20 proved as lacklustre as 2018–19 with GST gross revenues at Rs 12.22 lakh crore; an average of Rs 1,01,844 crore. In this year, GST gross revenues crossed the Rs 1 lakh crore mark in seven months out of twelve.

The growth rate of gross GST revenues was 19 per cent in 2018–19 over 2017–18 but only 3.8 per cent in 2019–20 over 2018–19. The growth rate of 2018–19 is also somewhat inaccurate as the collection in July 2017, the first month of GST rollout, was actually a ‘no revenue’ month as GST, except for imports, etc., is only due in the following month.

Performance in 2020–21 was impacted by the pandemic and lockdown. GST gross collections fell to Rs 32,294 crore in the month of April, then recovered partly to Rs 62,009 crore in May and Rs 90,917 crore in the month of June. GST revenues remained subdued until September 2020, when the gross revenues came to Rs 95,480 crore after two months of sub-Rs 90,000 crore revenues in July and August 2020. GST revenues crossed